

Hamas fighters' fate snags Gaza plan

BY LOVEDAY MORRIS,
LIOR SOROKA AND
HEBA FAROUK MAHFOUZ

A dispute over the fate of as many as 200 Hamas fighters trapped inside tunnels in an Israeli-controlled area of Gaza is complicating the Trump administration's efforts for peace, with the United States pressing Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu to give the militants safe passage.

The disagreement over the fighters, who became stranded behind Israeli lines in Rafah after a ceasefire was announced last month, has underscored the broader potential pitfalls of the deal — including the thorny issue of disarming Hamas and growing Israeli frustration over what some officials see as U.S. interference in the country's national security.

"The bottom line is that this problem could threaten the agreement, but American pressure is continuous," said a former Egyptian official with knowledge of the talks, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss the negotiations. Egypt has served as a key mediator in the talks and shares a roughly eight-mile border with the Gaza Strip that includes Rafah.

The former official said Jared Kushner, the son-in-law of President Donald Trump, who is in Israel this week, has pressed for a solution. The U.S. has emphasized that Israel should refrain from killing the militants, he said, adding that it would "detonate the ceasefire agreement and thus doom the Trump plan."

Trump's proposal, which he unveiled in September, laid out a 20-point plan for peace after two years of war, including the destruction of military and weap-

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Congress tightens THC restrictions on hemp

BY ANDREW JEONG

Congress on Wednesday stiffened restrictions on hemp, a form of the cannabis plant that was legalized in the 2018 farm bill, in a provision tucked into the legislation signed into law by President Donald Trump that ended the longest government shutdown in U.S. history.

The restrictions triggered protests from producers who have come to rely on the multibillion-dollar industry as a source of income. They aim to close a loophole that let market players sell unregulated food and beverages containing hemp-derived psychoactive compounds. The rules set a stricter limit on the amount of tetrahydrocannabinol, or THC, the intoxicating chemical also found in marijuana, that a hemp product can contain.

Hemp was once on the federal controlled substances list, but it was legalized in the 2018 farm bill by lawmakers who touted the crop's potential to boost farmers' incomes. Hemp can be used to make products such as rope,

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Federal firing: USDA plans to ax worker who gave TV interview. A6

Trump's schedule: Activities during shutdown broke with tradition. A7



TOM BRENNER/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

The D.C. mayor's delicate dance

Bowser has appeased the president, averting a federal takeover but frustrating constituents

BY JONATHAN O'CONNELL

President-elect Donald Trump was complaining about grimy tiles.

It was December 2024, and D.C. Mayor Muriel E. Bowser had traveled to Mar-a-Lago to forge a working relationship with the man who had pledged during his campaign to wrest control of the city's government upon his return to the White House.

In speeches, Trump had called D.C. a "horribly run" and "crime-ridden" city plagued by "filth and decay." Now, with the mayor sitting across from him inside his office at his Palm Beach, Florida, club, he aired a more specific criticism: The tiles lining a highway tunnel under the National Mall were dirty and worn.

"Tiles are old/395 Tunnel," Bowser (D) scribbled in green ink on the bottom-right corner of a sheet where she took color-coded notes during the wide-ranging, one-hour discussion.

Later that day, Bowser, whose defiant approach during Trump's first term made her a national figure in the Democratic resistance, announced she'd had "a great meeting" with Trump about their "shared priorities." Privately, she instructed her staff to



CAROLINE GUTMAN/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

TOP: D.C. Mayor Muriel E. Bowser (D) speaks to Police Chief Pamela A. Smith on Sept. 10. ABOVE: The mural at Black Lives Matter Plaza is removed.

inspect the Interstate 395 tunnel and find ways to brighten it up. Within weeks, city workers had switched on lights that had been left off to conserve energy and cleaned up their fixtures.

Bowser's response was an early example of the approach she has used to so far prevent a complete federal takeover of the city, including her effort this summer to end an emergency order that gave the Trump administration control of D.C. police for 30 days. Behind the scenes, Bowser has worked to appease Trump in both small and significant ways — and more often than has been publicly known — in the year since his reelection, a Washington Post examination found.

This account, which reconstructs key interactions in the mayor's effort to navigate Trump's demands, is based on extensive interviews with Bowser and more than 20 other people, including Trump Chief of Staff Susie Wiles, who attended the Mar-a-Lago meeting. Bowser also allowed a Post reporter to accompany her during some events while Trump's emergency order was in effect, to join meetings and phone calls with staff, and to review notes and internal mem-

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FIFA is about to take over the Kennedy Center at no cost

Soccer's world governing body will spend three weeks at the arts center, disrupting performances

BY JANAY KINGSBERRY
AND RICK MAESE

FIFA will not pay a rental fee when it takes over much of the Kennedy Center later this month for the 2026 World Cup draw, according to a copy of the venue use agreement obtained by The Washington Post and other internal documents. The center's arrangement with soccer's international governing body will disrupt its performance schedule, forcing the relocation or postponement of several concerts at an institution that has seen a sharp decline in ticket sales since it was taken over by President Donald Trump earlier this year.

To prepare for the draw, which is scheduled for Dec. 5, FIFA will occupy performance spaces and other sections of the Kennedy

Center for almost three weeks, according to the documents and a center employee who spoke on the condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to discuss the agreement.

Scheduled performances from the National Symphony Orchestra during that period — from Nov. 24 to Dec. 12 — have been postponed, said the person and another employee with knowledge of the changes who spoke on the condition of anonymity out of fear of reprisal. One NSO concert, a Dec. 9 performance to the movie "Home Alone," was moved to another venue in Washington, while one highlight of the orchestra season, NSO music director Gianandrea Noseda's concert weekend with opera singer Camilla Nylund, was moved to

SEE FIFA ON A11



RICKY CARIOTI/THE WASHINGTON POST

FIFA President Gianni Infantino will hold the draw for the World Cup in D.C. A copy of the contract indicates the space will be free.

Trump strikes a nerve in MAGA

RARE RESISTANCE
FROM FAITHFUL BASE

Epstein, immigration ire shows limits of his power

BY HANNAH KNOWLES

MAGA leaders erupted this week over President Donald Trump's assertion that the United States needs foreign workers because it does not have enough "talented people," questioning the president's commitment to the "America First" politics he popularized.

A congressional push to release the government's files on sex offender Jeffrey Epstein — a years-long cause on the right — moved forward against the wishes of the White House, even as Republicans overwhelmingly dismissed newly released emails Epstein wrote, including some about Trump.

And Rep. Marjorie Taylor Greene (R-Georgia), a longtime Trump ally, sparred with the president on multiple fronts after suggesting that the White House was too focused on foreign affairs and denouncing recent aid to Argentina.

The dissent showed an impassioned base willing to challenge Trump on some issues while largely supporting his leadership. Trump's critics voiced skepticism that the rifts will hurt the president's support in any lasting way. But the rare criticism showed the limits of Trump's authority over the "America

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The Take: One issue keeps driving a wedge between Trump, his base. A9

Obese people could now be rejected for U.S. visas

BY LAUREN KAORI GURLEY
AND HANNAH NATANSON

The Trump administration has directed visa officers to consider obesity — and other chronic health conditions such as heart disease, cancer and diabetes — as reasons to deny foreigners visas to the United States.

Secretary of State Marco Rubio told U.S. consulates and embassies around the world about the changes in a Nov. 6 cable, according to a copy obtained and verified by The Washington Post. The move broadens current medical screening beyond contagious diseases and gives visa officers new justification to reject applicants, in the Trump administration's latest effort to curb the flow of immigration.

"You must consider an applicant's health," said the State Department cable, which was reported earlier by KFF Health News. "Certain medical conditions — including, but not limited to, cardiovascular diseases, respiratory diseases, cancers, diabetes, metabolic diseases, neurological diseases, and mental health conditions — can require hundreds of thousands of dollars' worth of care."

The cable then suggests that consulates consider obesity in

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